



The Restaurant Playbook

Five workflows from the 9pm reservation request to the Tuesday private-event pitch -- built for owner-operators, GMs, and front-of-house leads.

What's inside

Reply to a 9pm reservation request with a booking confirmation under 90 seconds.

Write a weekly specials menu copy block that lifts order average without price hikes.

Recover the no-show on the Friday 8-top with a same-day waitlist text.

Quarterly private-event outreach that lands the Friday rehearsal dinner slot.

12 months of free updates — every improvement ships to your inbox

5 workflows · 5 copy-paste AI prompts & scripts · AI stack setup · 12 months of free updates

SkillForge AI — 2026 Edition



AI STACK

Your AI Stack — What to Buy, What to Skip

"AI stack" is just a fancy way of saying "the AI tools you pay for." Yours is short. That's the point.

Buy this: one chatbot subscription

Pick one of these. Either is fine. They both do everything in this book.

- ChatGPT Plus (OpenAI) — around \$20/month at the time of writing; check current pricing.
- Claude Pro (Anthropic) — around \$20/month at the time of writing; check current pricing.

That's it. One subscription, about twenty bucks a month. Everything in this playbook — every prompt, every workflow — runs on it.

Why paid instead of free?

The free versions work, but they cut you off when you use them heavily and they're slower during the day. For a business tool you lean on between jobs, the paid tier is worth it. Twenty dollars is less than the profit on a single private event.

Phone or computer? Both.

Install the app on your phone — that's where you'll use it most, in the office between services dictating notes. Use the website on your computer for longer writing sessions.

Maybe later: AI phone answering

If missed calls are your biggest leak — and during Friday dinner rush they are — an AI receptionist service that answers when you can't is the highest-return upgrade after the chatbot. It answers, takes the details, books the appointment, and texts you a summary.

This book doesn't recommend a specific provider, because the market moves fast and pricing changes. When you're ready, shop for one the way you'd shop for any subcontractor: get three options, ask what happens on a call you can't take at 2 PM on a Tuesday, and make sure you can listen to real sample calls before you commit.

Do not buy this on day one. Get comfortable with the chatbot first. Add phone answering later, once you've felt the savings.



AI STACK

Your AI Stack — What to Buy, What to Skip

Skip all of this

- "AI-powered" POS add-ons or reservation software sold to restaurants. Your front-of-house problem is solved with the chatbot and the systems you already have. Don't buy new software to fix a workflow problem.
- AI logo makers, AI website builders, AI business-card designers. Vanity purchases. They don't book jobs.
- Multiple chatbot subscriptions. You need one. ChatGPT and Claude is paying twice for the same thing.
- Anything that claims to "replace the chef" or "invent your menu." The food is yours — AI writes the words around it.

The stack, summarized

What	Cost	When
One chatbot subscription (ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro)	~\$20/month	Day one
AI phone answering	Varies — shop around	Later, only if missed calls are your top leak
Everything else	\$0	Skip it

Your total starting cost: about \$20/month. If this book saves you a single hour this month, it has paid for itself several times over.

Set it up once: teach the chatbot your business

Both ChatGPT and Claude let you save "custom instructions" — background info the AI remembers every time. Spend five minutes on this once, and every prompt in this book gets better, because the AI already knows who you are.

Fill this in and paste it into the custom instructions (usually under Settings → Personalization or similar):

I own [YOUR RESTAURANT NAME], a restaurant serving [SERVICE AREA]. We do dine-in, takeout, private events, and catering. My customers are diners and event planners. When you write for me: plain language, warm and inviting tone, no jargon. Never invent menu items, prices, or availability I didn't provide. Keep customer-facing writing short — under the word count I specify.



WORKFLOW 01 OF 05

No-Show Recovery -- The Friday 8-Top Waitlist

A three-touch no-show recovery cadence for the Friday 8-top no-show. Day 0 same-night waitlist text, Day 1 email, Day 14 same-week re-engagement.

Estimated time-to-run: 14 minutes per no-show, three sends total

1*ChatGPT or Claude*

HOW TO INPUT

1. Open the prompt at the moment the no-show signal fires.
2. Paste the party detail (name, party size, original booking time).
3. Replace the placeholders.
4. Send the SMS that night.

PROMPT

You are the front-of-house lead at a busy restaurant running the same-night no-show recovery on a Friday 8-top. Generate a 3-sentence SMS under 160 characters for the no-show party below. Sentence 1: a calm opener that does not use the phrase "we missed you". Sentence 2: a fact about what the kitchen just sent out (a Friday special, a wine pairing, a dessert special the chef dropped) that makes the guest feel seen without sounding like a pitch. Sentence 3: a single yes/no question about whether they want to swap to a different Friday-night window this month (name the next two specific windows). No exclamation points, no urgency pressure. Guest: [GUEST FIRST NAME]. Party: [PARTY SIZE]. Window 1: [WIN 1]. Window 2: [WIN 2].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A 160-character same-night no-show recovery SMS with two specific window options and one yes/no question.

Step time estimate: 4 minutes



WORKFLOW 02 OF 05

Private-Event Outreach -- The Quarterly Pitch

A four-touch quarterly private-event outreach cadence targeting past rehearsal-dinner, birthday, and corporate gathering hosts. Each touch has a season-specific hook and a single ask.

Estimated time-to-run: 20 minutes to set up; runs quarterly

1*ChatGPT or Claude*

HOW TO INPUT

1. Open the prompt at the start of the quarter.
2. Paste the past-event host list (1-3 detail lines per host).
3. Replace the placeholders.
4. Queue the 4 emails in your CRM as a triggered quarterly outreach.

PROMPT

You are the front-of-house lead at a restaurant running the quarterly private-event outreach. Below is the past host list. Generate the 4-touch sequence as a 4-row table (Host | Email Subject | Email Body -- 1 sentence teaser). Each touch: (1) opens with a [SEASON]-specific hook (a new spring prix-fixe menu, a fall harvest tasting, a holiday rehearsal-dinner package -- whichever fits); (2) names the past event the host ran at the restaurant (a 12-person rehearsal, a 30-person corporate dinner, a 60-person birthday) -- use the detail from the list; (3) closes with one yes/no question about whether they want to lock a specific date in the next 6 weeks. Tone: warm, plain English, no "we miss hosting you" filler. Past host list: [PASTE]. Quarter: [QUARTER].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A 4-row quarterly outreach table with hosts, subjects, and one-ask teasers tied to past events.

Step time estimate: 20 minutes



WORKFLOW 03 OF 05

Review Response -- The Same-Day Reply

A two-step prompt that turns a public review (positive or negative) into a same-day restaurant reply -- in the owner's voice -- without sounding promotional or defensive.

Estimated time-to-run: 8 minutes per review

1*ChatGPT or Claude*

HOW TO INPUT

1. Open the prompt at the morning review sweep.
2. Paste the review verbatim (rating + body) and the guest's first name.
3. Replace the placeholders.
4. Post the reply the same morning.

PROMPT

You are the owner of a busy restaurant composing a same-day public review reply. Below is the review. Generate a reply as 3 blocks: (1) a one-sentence opener -- thank the guest by first name, name the specific visit they referred to (a Tuesday dinner, a Friday 8-top, a Saturday brunch -- whichever fits); (2) a one-paragraph response in plain English that addresses the specific feedback they left (a positive on a specific dish, a constructive on a wait, a negative on service) -- never defensive, no "we appreciate your feedback"; (3) a one-line close that invites them back with one yes/no question about a specific visit (a Tuesday prix-fixe, a Friday 8-top window, a Saturday brunch). Tone: warm, owner voice, no exclamation points, no urgency. Review: [PASTE]. Guest first name: [GUEST FIRST NAME].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A 3-block same-day review reply in the owner's voice, ending on one yes/no question.

Step time estimate: 8 minutes



WORKFLOW 04 OF 05

Post-Dinner Email Capture -- The Loyalty Hook

A one-step prompt that turns the dinner check-out moment into a 3-sentence loyalty email capture -- the email that lands the next visit without sounding like a coupon.

Estimated time-to-run: 6 minutes per dinner

1*ChatGPT or Claude*

HOW TO INPUT

1. Open the prompt when the check is closed.
2. Paste one detail from the dinner the guest will remember (the dish, the server, the wine pairing).
3. Replace the placeholders.
4. Send before the guest reaches the parking lot.

PROMPT

You are the front-of-house lead at a restaurant running the post-dinner loyalty email capture. Below is the dinner detail. Generate a 3-sentence email under 120 words for the guest below. Sentence 1: thanks for the dinner tonight. Sentence 2: names the [DETAIL] -- no filler adjectives, no "we hope you enjoyed". Sentence 3: names the one specific thing the guest can pre-book for the next visit (a Tuesday prix-fixe, a Friday chef pairing, a Saturday brunch with a window table) with one yes/no question. Tone: warm, plain English, no exclamation points, no "see you soon" filler. Guest: [GUEST FIRST NAME]. Detail: [DETAIL].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A 120-word post-dinner loyalty email with a specific pre-book and one yes/no question.

Step time estimate: 6 minutes



WORKFLOW 05 OF 05

Catering Inquiry -- The 24-Hour Proposal

A two-step prompt that turns a catering inquiry into a 24-hour proposal with three tiered price points and the one seasonal hook the host will remember.

Estimated time-to-run: 30 minutes per inquiry

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ChatGPT or Claude

HOW TO INPUT

1. Open the prompt at the moment the catering inquiry comes in.
2. Paste the party detail (headcount, venue, dietary notes, date).
3. Replace the placeholders.
4. Send the proposal within 24 hours of the inquiry.

PROMPT

You are the front-of-house lead at a restaurant responding to a 24-hour catering inquiry. Below is the inquiry detail. Generate the proposal as four blocks: (1) the one-paragraph project description the host can sign off on -- headcount, venue, dietary notes, date -- in plain English; (2) three tiered price points (a family-style drop-off at \$X/person, a full-service buffet at \$Y/person, a plated service at \$Z/person) -- one yes/no question each; (3) one block naming the one seasonal hook the host will remember (a fall-harvest menu, a spring prix-fixe, a summer wine pairing) -- whichever fits the date; (4) the timing block -- the chef confirms within 2 hours of the host picking a tier, the delivery or service window lands on [DATE]. Numbers, no filler adjectives. Inquiry: [PASTE DETAIL].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A 4-block catering proposal with scope, three tiers, seasonal hook, and timing.

Step time estimate: 25 minutes